



Learn to navigate Group Work

AAU Student Guidance



AALBORG
UNIVERSITY

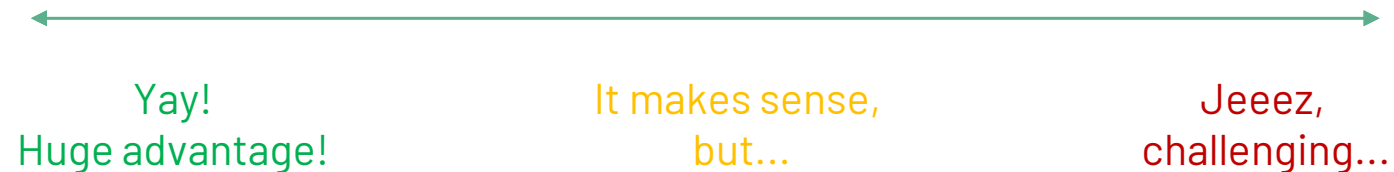
Agenda

- Why work in groups?
 - The reality is complex
 - What's in it for you?
 - Employability
- How challenging can it be?
 - What are the experiences of other international students?
- How to create the foundation for constructive group work
- Tools at your disposal



What are your experiences with group work?

- ▶ We are a product of our environment – what is your take on group work?



Why work in groups?

- ④ **You are part of a university-revolutionary history!**

- ④ ... with the establishment of AUC (now AAU) in 1974, they wanted to break with the prevailing form of teaching at the University!

- ④ **The ambition was:**

- ④ To create opportunities for wider groups of students from several different walks of life to complete a university education
- ④ The teaching and research should take place in closer collaboration with the surrounding society

Result = Project pedagogy – where group work and practice-oriented, socially relevant collaboration are key elements!



Why work in groups? The reality is complex!

- ▶ Real issues are complex!
 - ... and complex issues require complex processing and complex solutions



Why work in groups? What's in it for you?

- **Research shows that PBL and group work can lead to:**
 - Increased independence in knowledge acquisition
 - Improved ability for critical reflection
 - Increased competencies in cooperation and conflict management

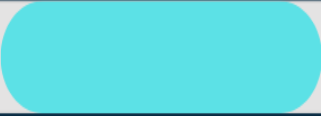


What does a group- and project process look like?

What to keep in mind that helps build a constructive group work:

- Show up on time
 - If you are sick, let your group members know ahead of time – e.g., the morning of
- Engage in academic discussions – it is expected that you express your opinion
- It is okay that discussions are passionate
- Actively participate in terms of fx delegating tasks and accepting responsibility
- It is expected that you have self-discipline and can deliver tasks, when it is expected of you – your group members are not to be responsible for checking up on whether you have completed a task or not

PLAN YOUR PROJECT

TASKS	FEBRUARY	MARCH	APRIL	MAY	JUNE
GROUP FORMATION PROCESS					
DEFINING A PROBLEM AND HANDING IN YOUR PROBLEM DEFINITION					
COLLABORATION WITH BUSINESSES, THEORY-SELECTION, GATHERING EMPIRICAL DATA					
WRITING THE ACTUAL PROJECT					
HANDING IN YOUR PROJECT					
PREPARING FOR ORAL DEFENCE/EXAM					
ORAL EXAM					

Why work in groups?

Employability



The good group collaboration – how challenging can it be?

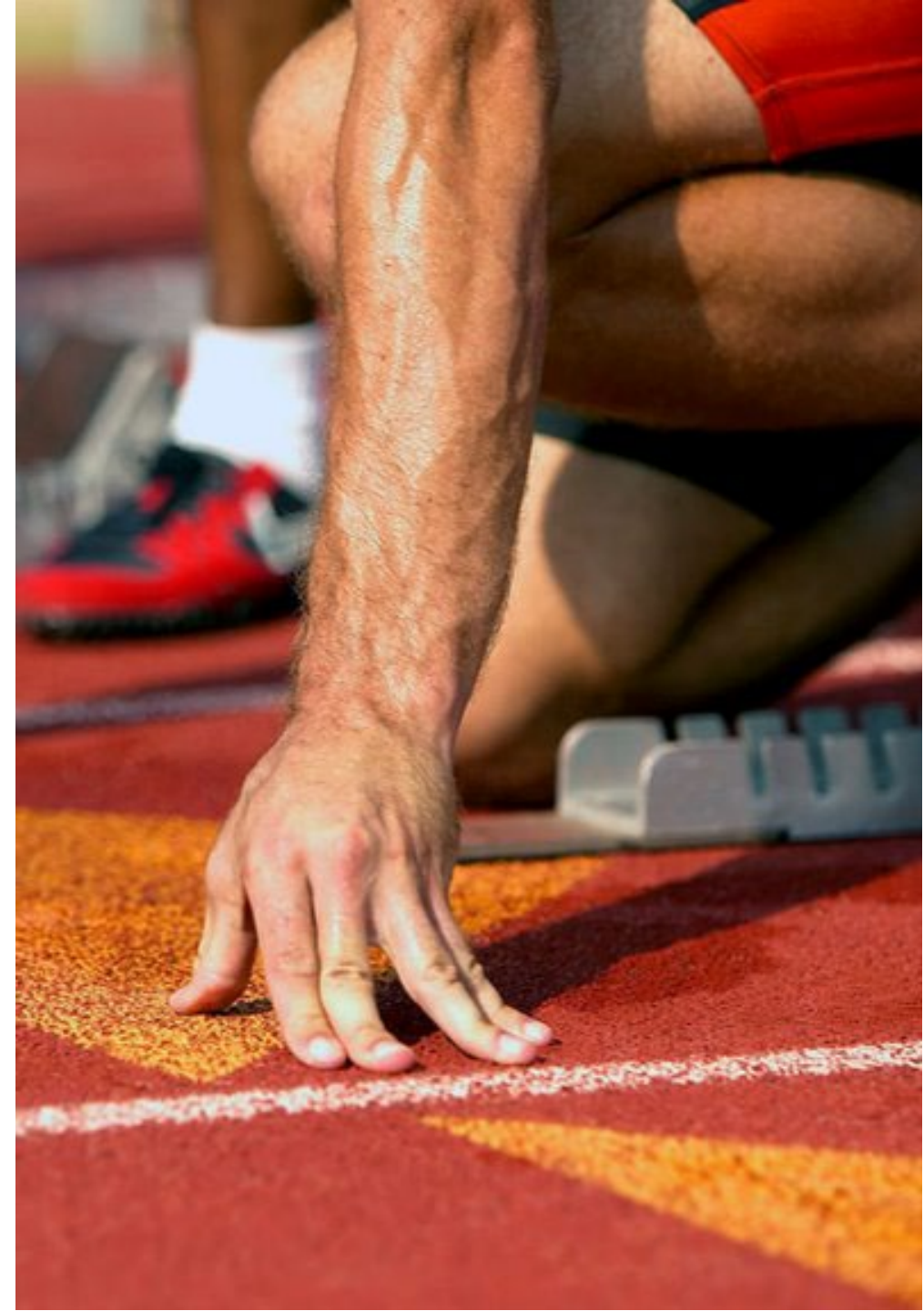
- **Almost half** of higher education students have experienced challenges associated with group collaboration
- **One in four** have experienced that the challenges have had consequences for their well-being and/or ability to perform optimally professionally
- **3 out of four** have experienced challenges 'from the outside' - that is, other students have had challenges that have affected well-being or performance
- **Other challenges mentioned?**
 - Lack understanding of the concept of group work as well as the concept of 'projects'
 - Difficulties in terms of language barriers
 - Differences in terms work-approaches (delegating tasks rather than solving them in collaboration)
 - How much time group work takes and is a part of being a student at AAU
 - Because of cultural differences, it can be difficult to engage in academic discussions – what is okay to say and what is not?

The good group collaboration – the bad strategies

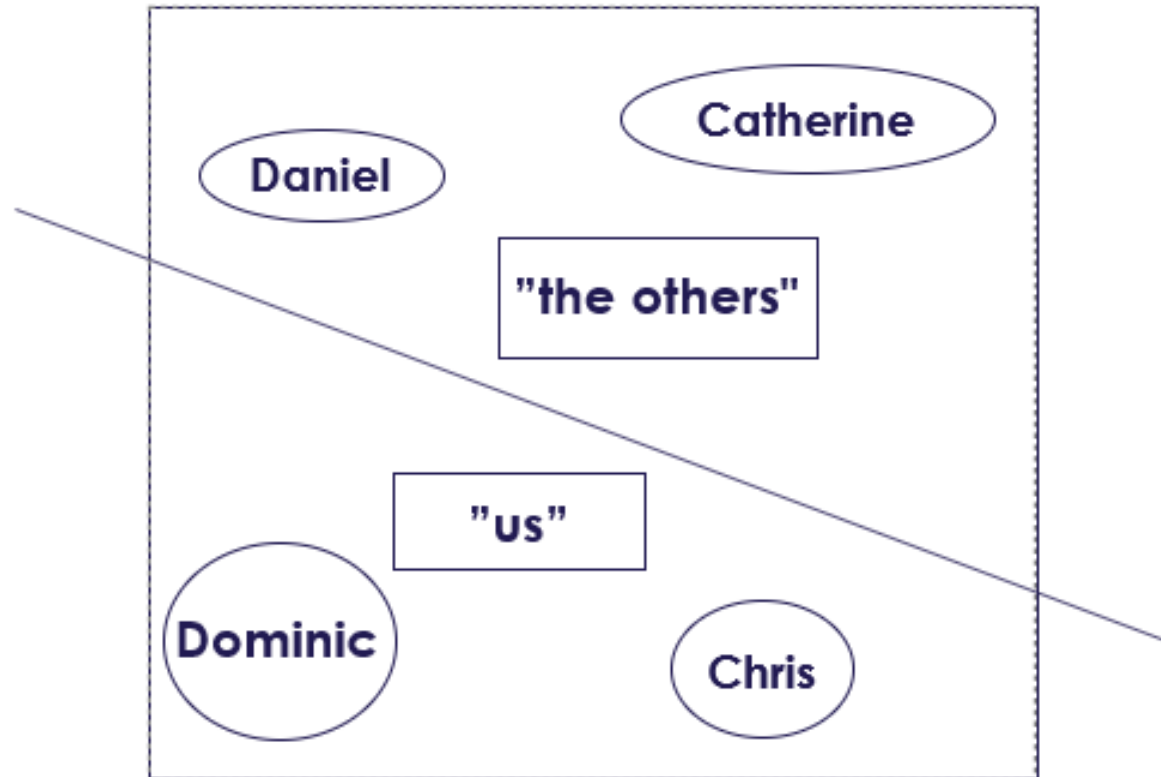
- ❶ "I don't care if the collaboration works – I just need to get an A+"
- ❷ "My group doesn't work very well. Next semester I'll just find a new group"

The good group collaboration – getting off to a good start

- ❶ **Focus on putting the group together in an appropriate way**
 - Relation versus reflection
- ❷ **Alignment of expectations**
 - How does the group work together?



How we form groups relationally



**Strength:**

The foundation of the group must be formed through relationships. Members are friendly and avoid conflicts.

Each student tries to form expectations of being a student.

Backside:

To succeed together, the group must dare to get out of this "comfort zone".

Strength:

Honest discussions, disagreements and evaluations of cooperation in study group. Typically happens at the first big task.

Backside:

The study group must be able to dare to disagree together. Otherwise, it leads to conflicts in the long term.

Strength:

The study group makes appointments, routines and a common "everyday life" for the work.

Backside:

Can be difficult to renegotiate established agreements, and hard for some students afterwards to break with the culture that the group has made.

Strength:

The study group optimizes the collaboration – based on the relationships, disagreements and agreements made beforehand. The study group has found effective work routines but can still stop and evaluate continuously.

Backside:

Not all study groups reach this level until change "pushes the group back"

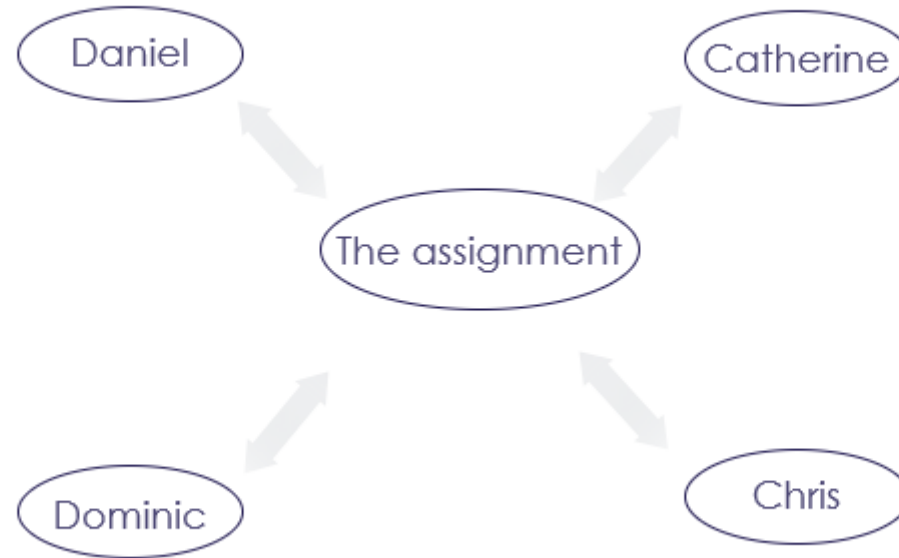
Strength:

Natural disintegration of a group, e.g. caused by semester completion or changes in assignment. Gives rise to get "closure" and evaluate on process.

Backside:

Can be dangerous and potentially painful for many students if the group dissolves prematurely due to conflicts, or if it is only a few students, that is excluded.

How we form groups reflexively



The good group collaboration starts with yourself

- How well do you know yourself?
[Free Personality Test | 16Personalities](#)



INTJ

Imaginative and strategic thinkers, with a plan for everything.



INTP

Innovative inventors with an unquenchable thirst for knowledge.



ENTJ

Bold, imaginative and strong-willed leaders, always finding a way - or making one.



ENTP

Smart and curious thinkers who cannot resist an intellectual challenge.

DIPLOMATS



INFJ

Quiet and mystical, yet very inspiring and tireless idealists.



INFP

Poetic, kind and altruistic people, always eager to help a good cause.



ENFJ

Charismatic and inspiring leaders, able to mesmerize their listeners.



ENFP

Enthusiastic, creative and sociable free spirits, who can always find a reason to smile.

SENTINELS



ISTJ

Practical and fact-minded individuals, whose reliability cannot be doubted.



ISFJ

Very dedicated and warm protectors, always ready to defend their loved ones.



ESTJ

Excellent administrators, unsurpassed at managing things - or people.



ESFJ

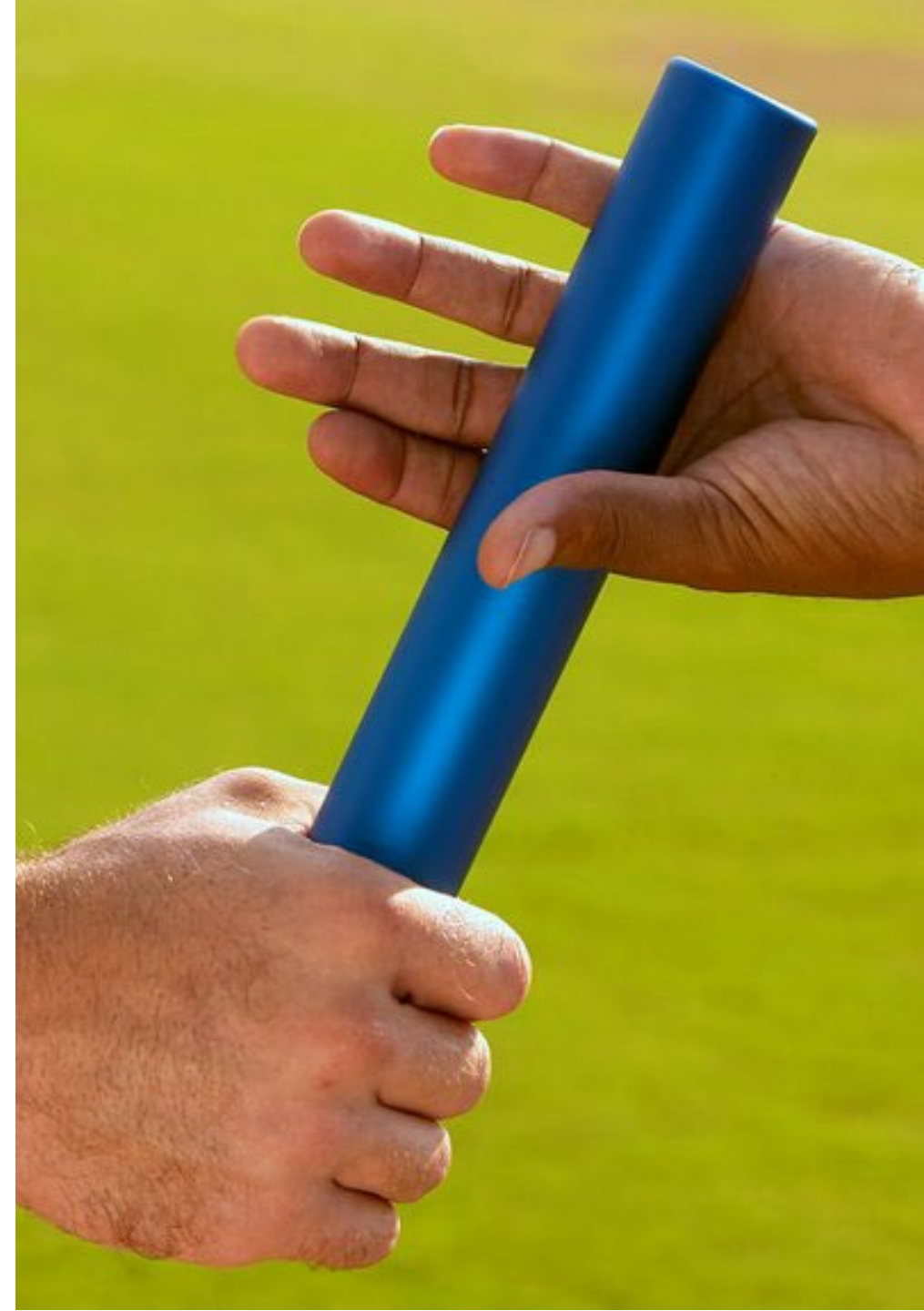
Extraordinarily caring, social and popular people, always eager to help.

EXPLORERS



"It's a personal assessment how much you want to invest in group work, but in the end it's just like with other team sports. If you don't run as fast as you can, when it's your turn, the others must run twice as fast when the dispatch has been passed on. Of course, you can't be a world champion at everything, but the main thing with good group work is that everyone comes in with a certain personal professional integrity and internal respect towards each other as fellow players. When you enter into a collaboration, you are not only responsible for your own learning, but also a responsibility to your group members."

Bachelor [ID Handbook 2023]



Balance your expectations within your group – your most important tool

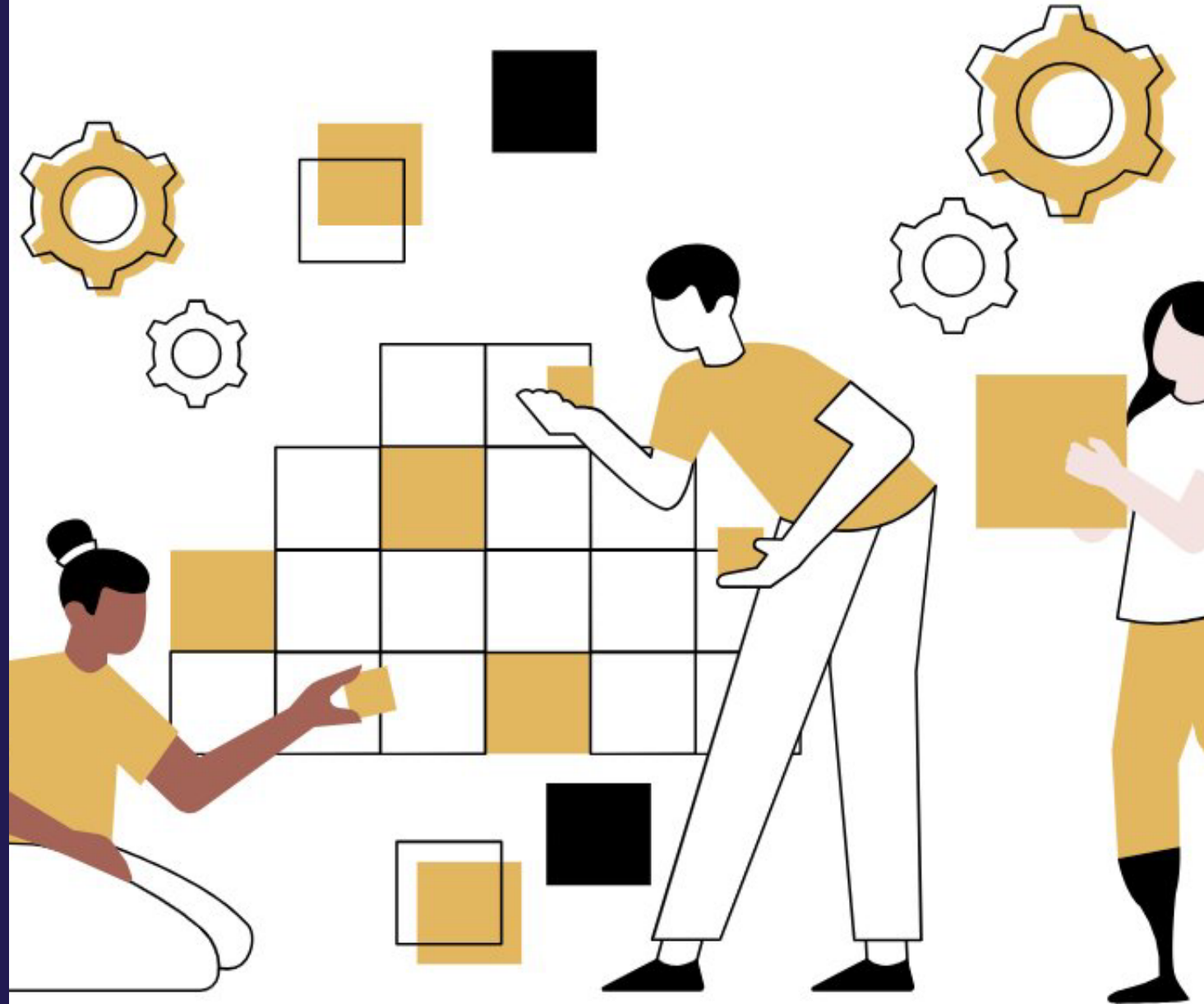
► The handshake – the five fingers

- Relations
- Direction
- Rules
- Framework
- Roles



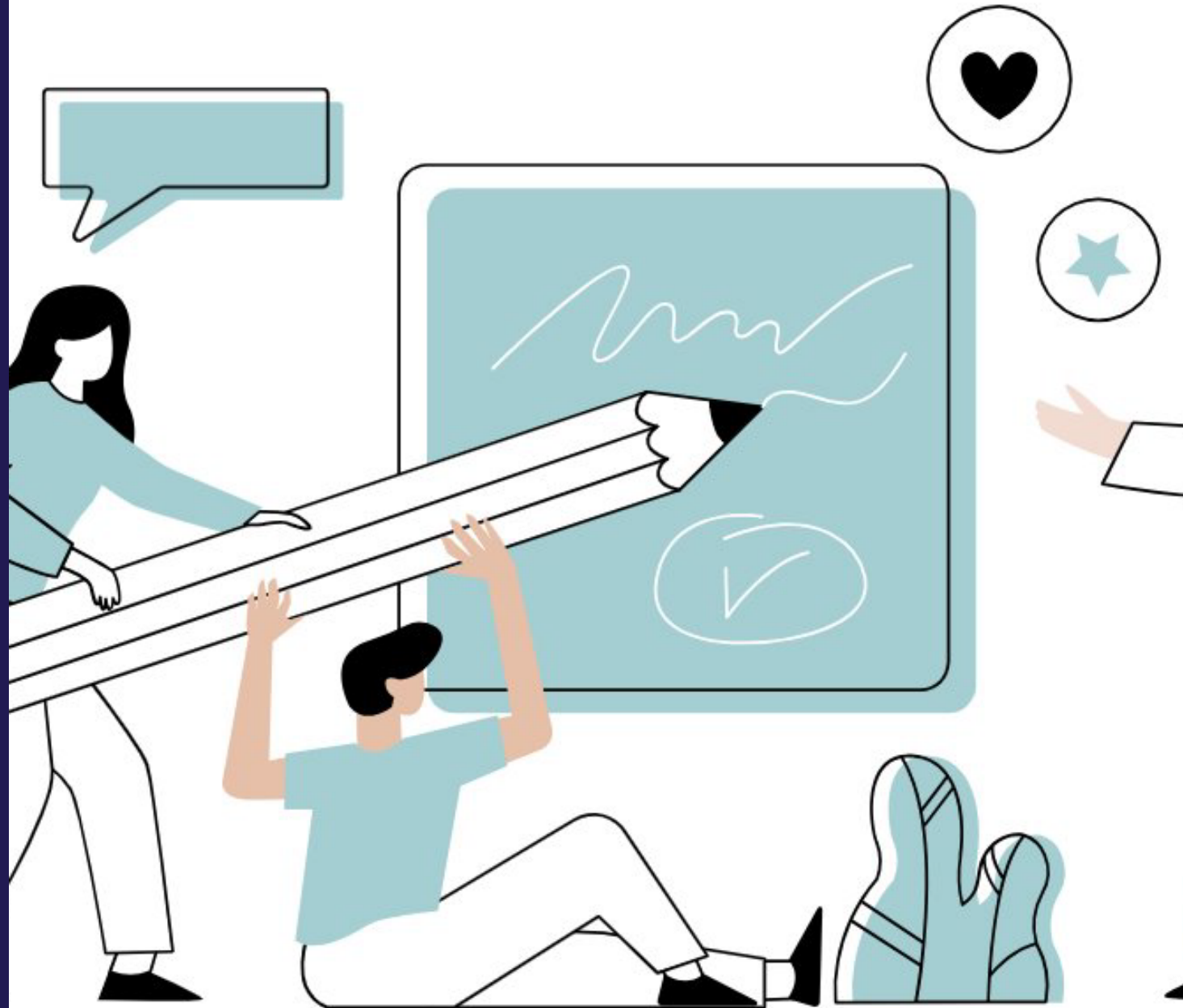
Relations

- ▶ How do we want social and labour relationships to develop between us – and how do we make it happen?
- ▶ What experiences do we bring with us from previous groups and what impact might this have on this group?
- ▶ What values should our cooperative relationship be based on?



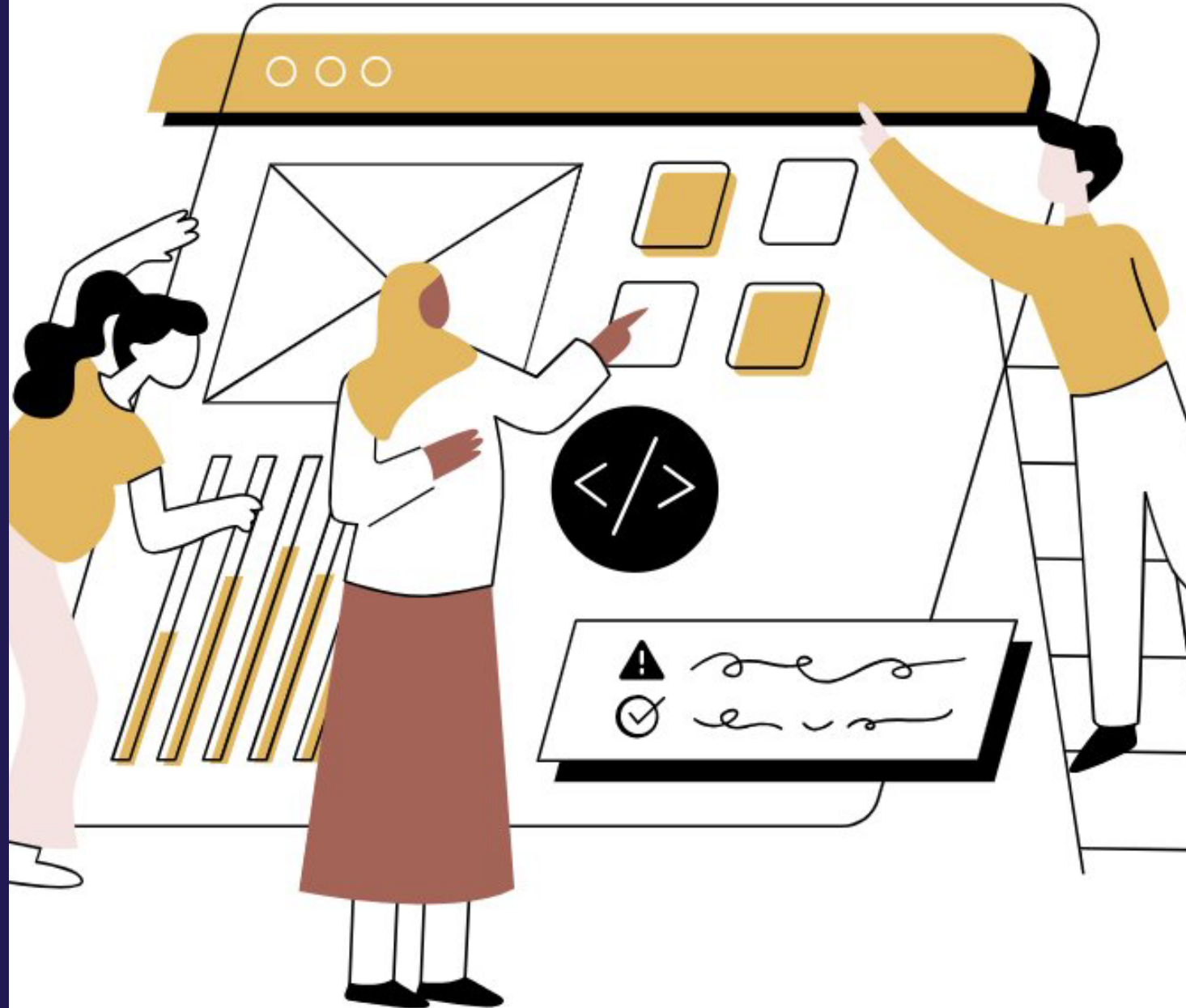
Direction

- ❖ **What do we want to do with the project?**
 - What goals and results are we working towards
 - What do we want out of it?
 - Do we agree on the intermediate objectives?
- ❖ **How do we ensure that everyone is going in the same direction?**
- ❖ **What do we do if we discover that we are going in different directions?**



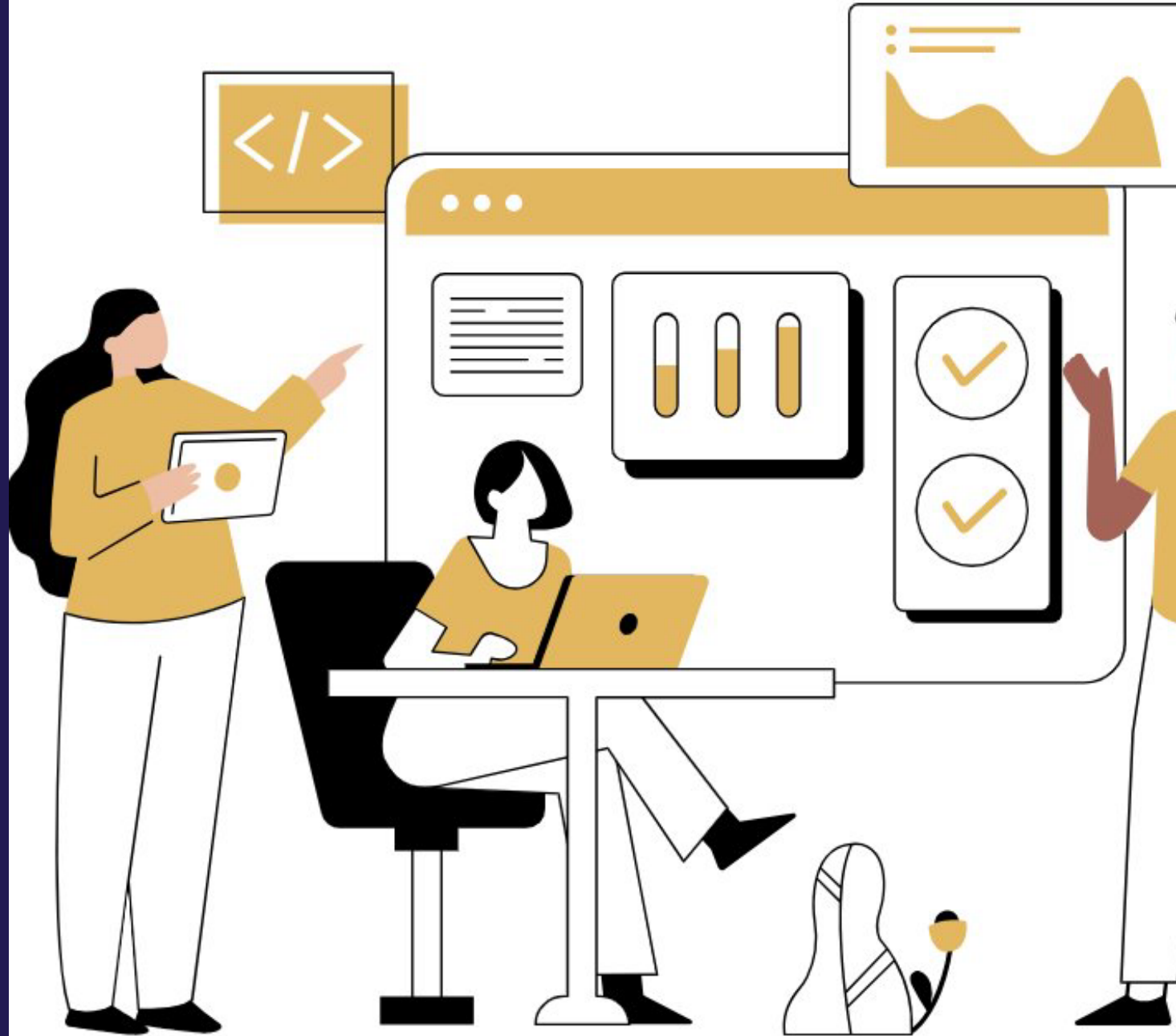
Rules

- ▶ What rules should apply in our group?
- ▶ How do we make them usable and how do we avoid that they limit our scope for action?
- ▶ What experience do we have with rules from other groups that can benefit this group?
- ▶ How do we take care of each other in during our cooperation, if and when the rules of the group work are interpreted differently and perhaps cause disappointments between us?



Framework

- ▶ What framework do we work within (time and resource, physical, etc.)?
- ▶ What positive experiences have you had/what has worked before?
- ▶ Can the frames be adjusted along the way – if so, in what situations and what could be adjusted?
 - Follow up during the semester
 - Does the framework still make sense?



Roles

- ▶ How do we divide the roles between us?
- ▶ What expectations do we have of each other in those roles we undertake?
- ▶ Can the roles be adjusted along the way – if so, in what situations?



Balance your expectations within your group – maintain your thoughts and decisions

► The handshake – the five fingers

- Relations
- Direction
- Rules
- Framework
- Roles



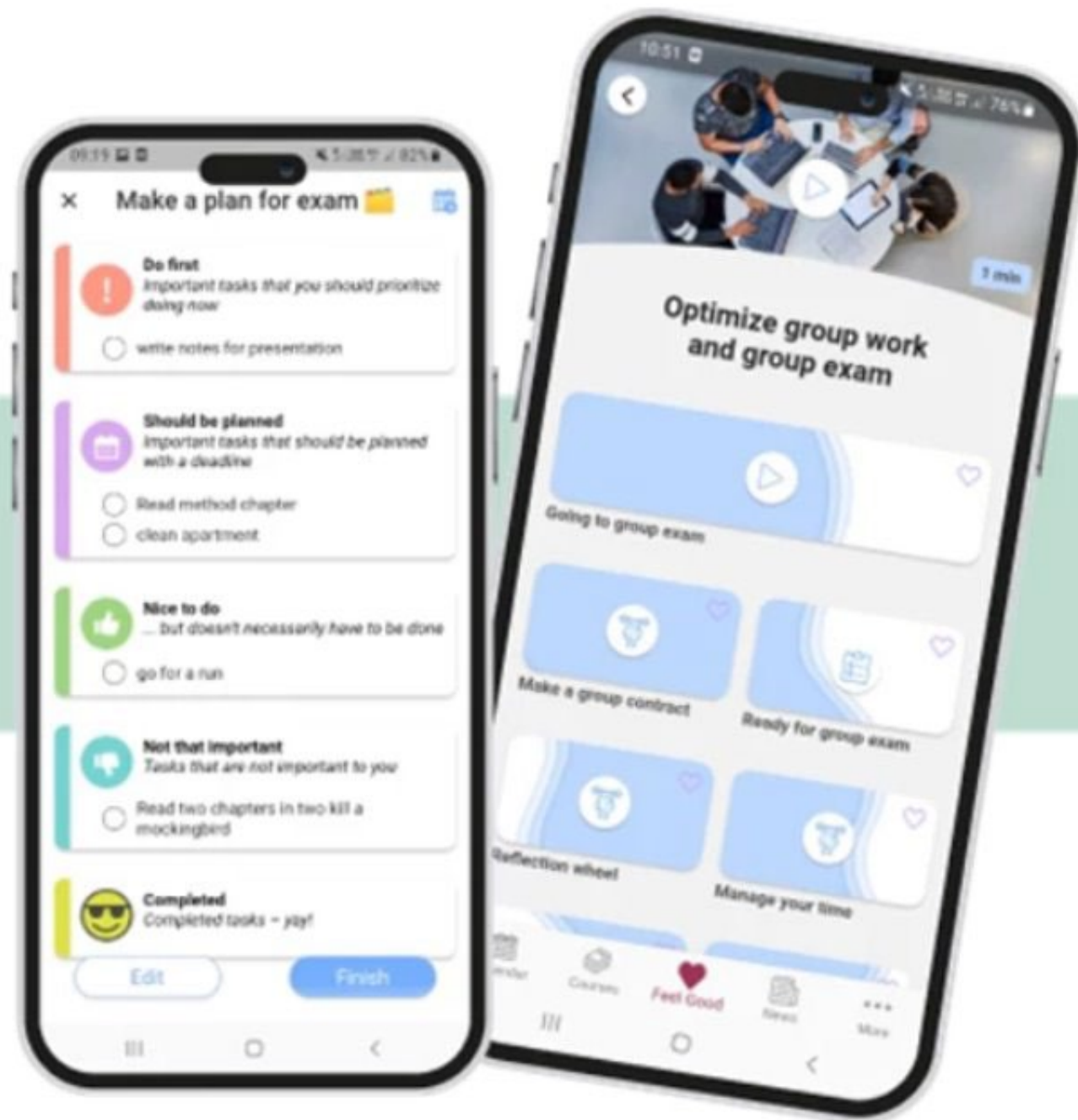
Tools close to you and the group

- ▶ The Feel Good Universe in AAU Student App
- ▶ [Group work - Aalborg University \(aau.dk\)](https://www.aau.dk)
- ▶ Conversations within the group



Tools close to you - 'Feel Good Universe' and AAU Student Guidance

- ▶ AAU Student App
 - The Feel Good Universe
- ▶ www.studentguidance.aau.dk



Key take aways

- Group formation – reflect upon the relationship that comes from the collaboration
- Take control of your collaboration – otherwise it will control you
- Your contribution - get to know your own preferences and 'run' to the best of your ability so that the 'dispatch' is well passed on

Reach out for support if things get tough – it's there!



"If you think 'whew' I'll never learn that group work, or how stupid it is, I promise you'll love it after studying! It may seem hard at first, but as soon as you stop talking about it all and take advantage of how many competencies you have within your group, you realize that teamwork is a huge strength. In addition, it will probably be much harder if you sit in teams at a workplace and no one understands what you say or mean. Enjoy getting to 'speak the same language'."

Alumnee [ID Handbook 2023]



How and where can you meet us?



Fredrik Bajers Vej 1, 9220 Aalborg Ø



E-mail: studentguidance@aaau.dk



Phone: 9940 9440



Web: www.studentguidance.aau.dk